

BETWEEN TWO RIVERS

The region of Mesopotamia lay in the fertile flood plain between the rivers Tigris and Euphrates. The name Mesopotamia means "between two rivers" in Greek.



Early civilizations

The world's earliest civilization emerged more than 6,000 years ago in an area of Mesopotamia (modern-day Iraq) called Sumer. For the first time, people lived and worked together in cities, governed by a king who made laws that everyone had to follow.

FROM HUNTING TO FARMING

When roaming hunter-gatherers started planting crops, they began to settle in one place and made farming tools instead of hunting weapons. Villages, towns, and eventually cities were established.



GREAT CITIES

As the Sumerian settlements grew, they formed cities, some of which became large and powerful city-states. Each city-state had its own leader, who ruled on behalf of the city's god.

URUK

Uruk was one of the first major cities in the world. Its most famous king was Gilgamesh, who was also the hero of one of the world's first known poems, *The Epic of Gilgamesh*.

AKKAD

This city was the centre of the world's first empire. In 2330 BCE, the Akkadians conquered many of their neighbouring city-states and took control of Mesopotamia.

BABYLON

The capital of the Babylonian Empire. At its peak around 550 BCE, the city's population was about 200,000.

NIMRUD

For a time, the capital of the Assyrian Empire. The magnificent palace of King Shalmaneser III covered over 50,000 sq m (538,196 sq ft) and had more than 200 rooms.

UR

Site of a huge ziggurat (pyramid-shaped temple) and the Royal Tombs, which contained some of the finest Mesopotamian art ever discovered.

BABYLON'S WONDERS

In 580 BCE King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon built a number of huge buildings in his capital, turning Babylon into the most magnificent city in the ancient world.

ISHTAR GATE

Gigantic main entrance to the city, designed to inspire awe in visitors.

ETEMENANKI ZIGGURAT

Temple of Marduk, patron god of Babylon. Rebuilt after it was destroyed in about 689 BCE.

HANGING GARDENS

Majestic terraced garden, one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World.



THE SUMERIANS CREATED THE FIRST CALENDAR BY DIVIDING THE YEAR INTO 12, BASED ON THE MOON'S MOVEMENTS

7000 BCE

People start to grow crops on a large scale in Mesopotamia.

5300 BCE

Large villages and small towns appear in Sumer.

Brick with inscription

3300 BCE

Sumerians invent a form of writing.

3000 BCE

Egypt: the pharaohs unite Egypt into a single state.

2334 BCE

King Sargon of Akkad conquers Sumer, creating the world's first empire.



Figure of Sumerian priest

c.2100 BCE

The great ziggurat (temple) built at Ur.

Ziggurat at Ur



539 BCE

Mesopotamia becomes part of Persia.

7000 BCE

CRADLE OF CIVILIZATION

The plain between the two great rivers of Mesopotamia was very fertile, with rich soil, a warm climate, reliable rainfall, and a wide range of plants and animals. It was the perfect place for early humans to put away their hunting spears and settle down in farming communities instead.

4000 BCE

The Sumerians build several cities in southern Mesopotamia.

3200 BCE

Greece: earliest civilizations appear.

2800 BCE

Peru: earliest civilization in the Americas.

2600 BCE

Northwest India: Indus civilization reaches its peak.

2200 BCE

China: first kingdom established.



Ornament from Royal Graves, Ur

c. 2500–2000 BCE

Huge cemetery complex built at Ur.

1300–1200 BCE

Assyrians conquer much of Mesopotamia.

753 BCE

City of Rome founded.



Sedu (Assyrian god)

500 BCE